Forming Negative Sentences

In French, to make a sentence negative, you usually use two words: "**ne**" and "**pas**." They go around the verb to show that something is not happening. But there are also other negative words you can use to say things like "**ne ... rien**," "**ne ... jamais**," or "**ne ... personne**," which make your sentences more specific.

Basic Negation: "Ne ... Pas"

The most common way to form a negative sentence in French is by using "**ne**" before the verb and "**pas**" after the verb.

Structure: Subject + ne + verb + pas

- Affirmative: Je mange. *(I eat.)*
- Negative: Je **ne mange pas**. *(I do not eat.)*
- Affirmative: Il parle français. *(He speaks French.)*
- Negative: Il **ne parle pas** français. *(He does not speak French.)*

Placement of "Ne" and "Pas" with Different Types of Verbs

1. Simple Tenses

- Affirmative: Tu comprends. *(You understand.)*
- Negative: Tu **ne comprends pas**. *(You do not understand.)*

2. Compound Tenses (with auxiliary verbs)

- Affirmative: Nous avons mangé. *(We ate.)*
- Negative: Nous **n'avons pas** mangé. *(We did not eat.)*

3. Infinitive Constructions

- Affirmative: Elle préfère manger. *(She prefers to eat.)*
- Negative: Elle préfère **ne pas manger**. *(She prefers not to eat.)*

4. Imperative Mood

- Affirmative: Parle ! *(Speak!)*
- Negative: **Ne parle pas** ! *(Do not speak!)*

Other Negative Expressions

Ne … rien *(nothing, not anything)*

- Affirmative: Je vois quelque chose. *(I see something.)*
- Negative: Je **ne vois rien**. *(I see nothing.)*

Ne … aucun(e) *(not any, none)*

- Affirmative: J'ai des amis ici. *(I have friends here.)*
- Negative: Je **n'ai aucun** ami ici. *(I do not have any friends here.)*

Ne … ni … ni *(neither … nor)*

- Affirmative: Il aime le café et le thé. *(He likes coffee and tea.)*
- Negative: Il **n'aime ni** le café **ni** le thé. *(He likes neither coffee nor tea.)*

Ne … personne *(nobody, no one)*

- Affirmative: Il connaît quelqu'un. *(He knows someone.)*
- Negative: Il **ne connaît personne**. *(He knows no one.)*

Ne … que *(only)*

- Affirmative: Elle mange des légumes. *(She eats vegetables.)*
- Negative: Elle **ne mange que** des légumes. *(She eats only vegetables.)*

